

Food

Centro Linguistico di Ateneo
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British Cuisine

Although Britain has a rich indigenous culinary tradition, its colonial history has profoundly enriched its native cooking traditions. British cuisine has in fact absorbed the cultural influences of its post-colonial territories, in particular, those of South Asia.

In ancient times, Celtic agriculture and animal breeding produced a wide variety of meats that the Anglo-Saxons learnt to stew with herbs a long time before the practice became common in Europe.
The Norman conquest in the Middle Ages introduced exotic spices into England, the knowledge of which was increased during the British Empire's domination of India through the importation of Indian cuisine and its strong, penetrating spices and herbs. Queen Victoria herself was a lover of Indian food and of curry!
However, during the wartime periods of the XX century, the food rationing policies enforced by the British government gave British cuisine its poor international reputation.

Well-known traditional British dishes include full breakfast, fish and chips, Christmas dinner, Sunday roast, steak and kidney pie, shepherd's pie, and bangers and mash. People in Britain, however, eat a wide variety of foods based on the cuisines of Europe, India, and other parts of the world.
British cuisine has many regional varieties. English, Scottish, Welsh and Northern Irish cuisines have each developed their own regional or local dishes, many of which are geographically indicated foods, such as Cornish pasties and the Yorkshire pudding.

British Cuisine

A **full English breakfast** is a very generous breakfast meal often served in the UK and Ireland. It seems that its origin dates back to the XIII century and to the old Anglo-Saxon tradition of hospitality, where households would offer big breakfasts to visiting friends, relatives and neighbours.
It typically includes fried bacon, fried sausages (called "bangers"), fried, poached or scrambled eggs, black pudding, baked beans, fried tomatoes, fried mushrooms, toast (toasted bread) and a beverage such as coffee or tea. Cereal or porridge is also sometimes served before the fried dishes, and buttered toast with marmalade or jam is served at the end. Alternative main dishes are kippers (a smoked herring, a fish), kedgeree (a dish of rice and kippers), and devilled kidneys (spicy lamb's kidneys). Bubble and Squeak (potato and cabbage) is also served.

While it is colloquially known as a "**fry up**" in most areas of Britain and Ireland, it is usually referred to as a "**full English breakfast**" in England (often shortened to "full English"), and as a "full Irish" in the Republic of Ireland, "full Scottish" in Scotland, "full Welsh" in Wales, "full Cornish" In Cornwall, and "Ulster fry" in Northern Ireland.
The **Full English** was also called **Full Monty**, after the World War II British Army general Bernard Montgomery (nicknamed Monty), who was said to have started every day with a full English breakfast when in the campaign in North Africa.

It is so popular in Britain and Ireland that many cafés and pubs offer the meal at any time of day as an "**all-day breakfast**". It is also popular in other English-speaking countries, particularly those that were once a part of the British Empire.

British Cuisine

Fish and chips is a very common takeaway food in the UK. As the name implies, it consists of fish that is fried in batter, accompanied by potato chips dressed in malt vinegar. Fresh cod or haddock are the most common fish used for this dish. Fish and chips are normally bought at a shop called "Chippie", to take away.
It was traditionally served wrapped in old newspaper, until a more hygienic paper wrap replaced the newspaper. A lot of restaurants offer fish and chips as Friday specials in regards to the traditional no-meat fast of Roman Catholics during Fridays.

Roast dinner (or classically known as **Sunday roast**) has become one of the main British meals.
It consists of roast meat, vegetables and a variety of accompaniments such as Yorkshire pudding and English mustard.
The term 'Sunday roast' comes from the origin of this dish, as it is the traditional meal of British families after attending Mass on Sundays.
The festive day starts by placing the meat into a baking dish, adding the vegetables and popping it into the oven, before going to Church.
After Mass, families will come home to the mouth-watering smell of a perfectly-roasted dinner!

British Cuisine

Roasted meats are meats that are cooked in the oven for at least two hours. Typical meats are joints of pork, beef, mutton, lamb or whole chickens. Also duck, goose, turkey and game are cooked this way.
The meats are served with traditional accompaniments, such as English mustard or Yorkshire Pudding for beef, mint sauce for lamb, and apple sauce for pork.

Yorkshire Pudding is not eaten as a dessert, like other puddings, but instead as part of the main course or as a starter.
It is a sort of batter made from eggs, flour and milk which is baked in the oven in a particular rounded baking tray, similar to a muffin tin, and served with gravy.

Toad-in-the-hole are sausages covered in batter and baked in the oven. It is similar to Yorkshire Pudding, but sausages are put into the batter before baking.

Shepherd's Pie is a savoury pie made with minced lamb and vegetables, covered with mashed potatoes.

Bangers and Mash are mashed potatoes and sausages. The reason why the sausages are called "bangers" is that during wartime rationing they were so filled with water, that they often exploded when they were fried.

Black Pudding, or **Blood Pudding**, is not a pudding. It looks like a black sausage and is made from dried pig's blood and fat, and is served at breakfast.

Haggis is a savoury pudding containing sheep's heart, liver, and lungs, minced with onion, oatmeal, suet, spices, and salt, mixed with stock and traditionally cooked in the sheep's stomach. It is the Scottish national dish.

British Cuisine

A Good Cup of Tea ('a cuppa')

The British population is one of the largest tea consumers in the world. Until the XVIII century it was a drink enjoyed only by the upper-class. However, from then on, every social class has made drinking tea a part of its daily habit.

The British Empire Tea Bureau released an instructional film about the proper serving of tea in the late 1940s. The instructions are as follows:

- Always use good-quality tea.
- Use freshly-drawn water.
- Warm the pot.
- Measure tea carefully in the correct proportion to the water (1 tsp per person + 1 for the pot).
- Use freshly-boiled water.
- Let the tea infuse properly before serving.
- Adding milk is a *must* for a good cup of tea!

But why is tea so important to the English? It is because they thought it had healing properties. When they drunk tea, they felt better and didn't have the health problems they usually suffered from. The reason behind this wasn't in the tea itself, but in the fact that in order to brew a cup of tea, the water, which was taken directly from the Thames, at the time one of the most polluted rivers in the world, had to be **boiled**. This simple action killed the germs and bacteria in the water, making it safe to drink and making the population healthier!

British Cuisine

Wassailing has been associated with Christmas and New Year as far back as the 1400s. It was a way of passing on good wishes among family and friends.

Wassail is an ale-based drink seasoned with spices and honey. It was served from huge bowls, often made of silver or pewter. The Wassail bowl would be passed around with the greeting, 'Wassail'.

Wassail gets its name from the Old English term "**Waes Hael**", meaning "be well". It was a Saxon custom that, at the start of each year, the lord of the manor would shout "**Waes Hael**!" The assembled crowd would reply "**Drinc Hael**!", meaning 'drink and be healthy'.

As time passed, the tradition was carried on by people going from door to door, bringing good wishes and a wassail bowl of hot, spiced ale. In return people in the houses gave them drink, money and Christmas fare (special foods eaten during Christmas time, for example mince pies) and they believed they would receive good luck for the year to come.

The contents of the bowl varied in different parts of the country, but a popular one was known as 'lambs wool'. It consisted of hot ale, roasted crab apples, sugar, spices, eggs, and cream served with little pieces of toast. It was the toast floating on the top that made it look like lamb's wool.

Today the wassail songs are being sung again at farms and pubs in several parts of England by people who decided to revive the old custom of blessing the crops and singing to good health.

Meals in Great Britain

Breakfast	the first meal of the day, usually eaten in the morning. The English word refers to breaking the fasting of the previous night.
Elevenses	a short break taken at around 11am, to consume a drink or a snack.
Brunch	is a combination of breakfast and lunch and is usually served before 3:00 pm, mostly on Sundays.
Lunch	an abbreviation for luncheon, a meal eaten around midday.
Afternoon Tea	is a light meal served today between 3:30 and 5pm.
Dinner	in many Western cultures the main meal of the day. Historically, dinner was served at midday, and supper was the light meal after tea. Christmas Dinner is, in fact a luncheon.
Supper	originally a light secondary evening meal, to be served after tea.
Snack	small serving of food between meals.

At the Restaurant

Full course dinner	a dinner consisting of multiple dishes, or courses. In its simplest form, it can consist of three or four courses, for example a first course, a main course and a dessert.
Tasting menu	a collection of several dishes in small portions, served by a restaurant as a single meal. In France it is called *menu degustation*, while in Italy it is referred to as *menu degustazione*.
Amuse-bouche	or amuse-gueule is a single, bite-sized hors d'oeuvre. They are different from appetisers as they are served free and according to the chef's selection alone.
Hors d'oeuvre	appetiser or starter is a small dish served before a meal in European cuisine. Some are served cold, others are served hot. Hors d'oeuvres may be served at the dinner table as a part of the meal, or before seating.
Soup	a primarily liquid food, generally served warm or hot, before the entrée.
Entrée	a dish served before the main course of a meal which can consist of various dishes, from a savoury pie, to a pasta dish.
Roast	a roasted dish of fish or meat.
Main Course	is the main dish in a meal, which can consist of various dishes, usually meat.
Salad	a mixture of vegetables and sometimes fruit.
Side dish	sometimes referred to as a 'side order' or simply a 'side', is the food item that accompanies the entrée or main course of a meal
Entremet	historically small dishes served between courses, which today can refer to a sherbet.
Dessert	is the course that concludes a meal, usually consisting of sweet foods and possibly a beverage such as a dessert wine or sweet liqueur. It can also be a selection of cheeses.

Pub Culture

The term **pub** is a short term for "public house." True to its origin, a British pub is a place in the neighbourhood where people gather for drinks and discussions after a long day of work.

The prevalent culture in British pubs is very different from American bars. A member's only policy is very common in British towns and villages.

Here are some of the unwritten laws in a British pub:

- Order from the bar and not from your table. Pubs do not usually have table service.
- When seated with a group, one should get the order for everybody, so as not to crowd the bar.
- When ordering beer, be specific: ale (dark beer), lager (light beer), bitter (light ale) or stout (very dark beer).
- Most pubs only take cash as payment. Be ready to pay as you order, but don't wave your money to call the bartender's attention, as it is frowned upon.
- To tip your waiter, offer him or her a drink. It will be added to your tab. If there is a tip jar, you can put your tip in it, as cash tips are welcome.
- If someone buys you or your table a round, it is customary for the next round to be on you.
- One ring of the bell from the bar means "last order". Two rings means the pub is closed.

5 Tips for Ordering Food and Drinks in English

1. Start Off With a Greeting

Politeness is everything when ordering!

Most places have employees who are paid mostly through tips.
Tips are based on how well they provided service. This means that the employees will try hard to make you happy.
Usually, when you go to the counter to order they will say "Hello" and they might ask "How are you today?"

You always want to return their "Hello" and ask "How are you?" If they don't say Hello" first when you get to the counter, it sounds most natural to order by saying, "Hi, can I get a ___?"

This is the best way to start an order because it shows respect for the employee. You can choose any friendly greeting to start off the conversation, like **Hello**, **Hi**, **Hey** or **How's it going**? (listed in order from most formal to most casual).
Usually, you'll want to match the level of formality to the person who talks first. This means if they say "Hi", then you say "Hi." If they say "Hello", then so do you!

5 Tips for Ordering Food and Drinks in English

2. Ask If You Can Get Something

Being polite goes a long way in any language!
When most native speakers order something, instead of saying, "I want ___", they'll ask "Can I get ___"
This sounds less demanding and can help the flow of the conversation. Firstly, if they don't have what you want, it sounds more natural to change your order. Second, it makes you sound more polite to the person you're ordering from.

Here are a few examples. Imagine you're in a café and you'd like to get a cappuccino.
1. "Can I get a cappuccino, please?"
2. "May I have a cappuccino, please?"
3. "Do you have cappuccino?"
4. "Can I order a cappuccino?"

They're all questions instead of demands. Especially when talking to strangers, you want to sound more passive (casual and polite). If the answer to your request is "no" for any reason, you can quickly change your mind and say something like, "Oh, alright. Then can I have an Espresso, please? Or "Can I have an Americano, please?" (Americano is a coffee drink made from espresso and hot water.) The reply will usually be something like, "Yes, you can. Anything else?"

5 Tips for Ordering Food and Drinks in English

3. For Here or To Go?
In some countries the expression for taking your food with you outside the restaurant, is **to go** or **take out**.
However, **to go** is usually used for both drinks and food (and anything else you might consume), while **take out** is only used for food.
To go is far more commonly used by English speakers.

When you want to order your food and take it with you, there are a few options.
"Can I get this to go?"
"I'd like the Fish and Chips, to go please."
"Can I have the Steak and Kidney pie? Take out."

If a place says that they have take out, they'll probably ask you if your order is "for here or to go". If they don't ask you that, make sure you tell them what you want before paying. (Some places charge different amounts depending on which one you choose.)

If you want to eat in the restaurant, you simply say, "for here" or "for here, please."

5 Tips for Ordering Food and Drinks in English

4. Yeah or Yes

Some people say that using **yeah** isn't a very polite way to talk, but it's way more casual and comfortable for most native English speakers.

If you're in a formal restaurant or hotel café, you will want to use "**yes**". If you're in any casual dining place, it's not necessary. If your answer is yes to any question, you can nod your head (up and down a little) and reply with **yeah**, **yep**, **sure** or a "**mhmm**" sound. If you're smiling and happily say "yeah": it isn't rude. If you're not paying attention and mumble "yeah", it's then considered rude. Here are some examples of casual alternatives (different choices) to yes.

"Is that all you'll be ordering?" "Yeah."
"Would you like this to go?" "Yep."

Another note is that when you do use "yes" to answer a question about adding anything, you want to say, "yes, please". However, "yeah, please" sounds a bit strange.

"Would you like cheese with that?" "Yes, please."
"Would you like whipped cream?" "Yes, please."

These words are generally said together quickly as if they were one long word. Because it's a phrase, you say the words close together instead of including the pause. The longer you pause between the two the more formal, and eventually awkward, it'll sound. The same can be said about "No, thank you".

5 Tips for Ordering Food and Drinks in English

5. Always Be Prepared for Extra Questions
Especially when you go to a sit-down restaurant (this is a term for any restaurant that isn't fast food or take out, but it doesn't have to be anything expensive either) you may have more questions asked while ordering and after ordering.

It's best to pause for a short amount of time after ordering each item. That way, the employee can ask you more questions! When ordering a coffee, you may need to specify if you'd like it iced (cold) or hot, or what size you want. Some places will ask you if you want cream and sugar, and then they'll add it for you.

If you order eggs or steak you need to answer how you'd like them cooked.
A steak can be well done (cooked thoroughly), medium (average) or rare (less cooked, still red inside).
Eggs may be scrambled (mixed up and cooked in little bits), omelets (cooked in a circle and folded), over easy (a simple fried egg) and sunny side up (fried egg cooked only on the bottom side, so the yolk — the yellow part — on top stays liquid).
You may be asked if you'd like any fillings (cheese, meat, vegetables and other things to put inside the egg) or side dishes (smaller plates of food which accompany the main meal). You may also be asked if you want something on top of your food, a certain preparation style for your food, if you'd like to order any desserts and much more.

Always be polite and answer these questions, and never forget to end with a "thank you"
When the time comes to pay for the meal, they may ask you if you're paying with credit, debit or cash. Always give time to let the employee ask these things.

5 Tips for Ordering Food and Drinks in English

Let's practice!

Now that we've talked about the different tips, let's try putting them together in one sample conversation that you can use to practice.

Waiter "Hello, welcome to The Coffee House. How are you today?"
You "Hello, I'm pretty good, how are you?"
Waiter "I'm great, thanks for asking. What can I get for you today?"
You "Can I get a large coffee, please? With cream and sugar."
Waiter "Yes, is that all for you today?"
You "Yeah."
Waiter "Would you like to try our new chocolate scone?"
You "No, thank you."
Waiter "Alright, one large coffee. Your total is £2.50. Will that be cash or card?"
You "Card, please."
Waiter "Please sign…here's your receipt."
You "Thank you."
Waiter "Please wait at the counter over there for your coffee. Thank you, have a nice day!"
You "Thank you, you too."